

RENANCE

PETROLEUM TRAINING INSTITUTE, EFFURUN

GNS 102 — Past Questions & Materials

by Renance

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Paper 1 of 2 — GNS 102 Note

Level ND1 • First Semester • Handout

GNS 102 NOTES

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COMMUNICATION

What is Communication?

Communication is the process of exchanging information, ideas, thoughts or feelings between individuals or groups. It is an essential aspect of human interaction and it plays a vital role in conveying (transferring) thoughts, emotions and intentions. Communication can occur through various channels such as spoken or written language, gestures (signaling with any part of the body especially the head or hand, to express an idea or meaning.), facial expressions, and even through visual or auditory signals. Communication is innate, that means everyone is born with the ability to communicate. Babies learn to communicate by crying, kicking and smiling.

Frank Hartman defines communication as “Control of behaviour through descriptive and reinforcing stimuli”. Hartman implies that an attempt at communication is an attempt at controlling the behaviour of people.

Descriptive and

COMMUNICATION CONTROL OF BEHAVIOUR

Reinforcing Stimuli

Chappel and Read define communication as “any means by which thought is transferred from one person to another”. Here, we see communication involving at least two persons. This implies that there is an individual who attempts through whatever means to transfer thought to another person.

1

According to Goyer 1989, communication is an occurrence involving a minimum of four sequential ingredients: (1) a generator of a (2) sign-symbol which is (3) projected to (4) at least one receiver who assigns meanings.

A GENERATOR SIGN SYMBOLS PROJECTED TO A RECEIVER

According to Keyton 2011, Communication can be defined as the process of transmitting information and common understanding from one person to another.

Coates 2009 gave three simple definitions of communication as:

Communication is the sharing of information.

Communication is the giving and receiving of messages.

Communication is the transfer of information from one or more people to one or more people.

De Vito 1986 explains Communication as the process of transmitting a message from a sender to a receiver through a channel and with the interference of noise.

Note that Communication is not just the giving of information; it is the giving of understandable information, and the receiving, and understanding of the message. Ultimately, for the purpose of this course, we may define communication as a goal oriented process, by which messages are passed from sources to receivers through adequate channels.

GOAL MESSAGES FROM TO THROUGH

ORIENTED ARE SOURCES RECEIVERS ADEQUATE

→ → → →

PROCESS PASSED CHANNELS

2

METHODS OF COMMUNICATION

There are basically two broad methods of communication; Verbal, and Non-verbal.

Communication can further be categorized into Inter-personal and Intra-personal communication.

Verbal Communication

Verbal communication refers to the use of spoken or written words to convey a message. It is the most direct form of communication and is commonly used in both formal and informal settings.

Types of Verbal Communication:

Oral Verbal Communication: Includes face-to-face conversations, telephone calls, lectures, speeches, and interviews.

Written Verbal Communication: Includes emails, letters, reports, text messages, articles, and books.

Key Features of Verbal Communication

It requires a shared language between the sender and receiver.

It allows for immediate feedback (especially in spoken form).

It can be formal or informal.

It is structured and can be documented (in written form).

Examples of Verbal Communication

A lecturer explaining a topic to students.

A manager writing an email to staff.

A news anchor reporting on television.

Importance of Verbal Communication

Facilitates clarity and accuracy.

Helps in effective teaching, learning, and workplace interaction.

Supports official and legal documentation.

3

Non-Verbal Communication

Non-verbal communication is the transmission of messages without the use of words. It includes

gestures, facial expressions, body posture, eye contact, tone of voice, and use of space (proxemics).

Components of Non-Verbal Communication:

Kinesics: Body movement such as gestures, facial expressions, posture.

Paralanguage: Tone, pitch, and speed of speaking.

Proxemics: Use of space and physical distance.

Haptics: Use of touch (e.g., handshake, pat on the back).

Appearance: Clothing, grooming, and overall physical presentation.

Chronemics: Use of time, such as punctuality.

Key Features

It is often subconscious and spontaneous.

It supports, complements, or contradicts verbal communication.

It can communicate emotions more effectively than words.

Examples

Smiling to show friendliness.

Folding arms to indicate defensiveness or disinterest.

Maintaining eye contact to show attentiveness.

Importance

Enhances understanding of the speaker's true feelings.

Helps to build trust and emotional connection.

Crucial in cultures where body language plays a strong role in communication

Interpersonal Communication

Interpersonal communication is the exchange of information between two or more people. It can occur in formal or informal contexts and may involve verbal, non-verbal, or written means.

Forms of Interpersonal Communication:

Dyadic communication: Between two people (e.g., friend-to-friend, doctor-patient).

4

Group communication: Small group discussions or teamwork.

Public communication: One person communicating with a larger audience.

Key Features

It involves interaction and feedback.

It can be face-to-face or mediated (e.g., phone, email, social media).

It is dynamic, transactional, and context-dependent.

Examples

A job interview.

A parent discussing academic performance with a teacher.

Two colleagues collaborating on a project.

Importance

Builds relationships and social connections.

Enables effective teamwork and collaboration.

Helps resolve conflicts and enhance understanding.

Intrapersonal Communication

Intrapersonal communication is the internal dialogue or communication that takes place within an individual. It includes thinking, reflection, self-talk, decision-making, and emotional processing.

Forms of Intrapersonal Communication

Self-concept: How you see yourself.

Internal dialogue: Silent self-talk or mental rehearsal.

Emotional reflection: Processing feelings and reactions.

Key Features

Private and silent.

Helps in personal reasoning and emotional regulation.

Influences one's confidence, behavior, and choices.

Examples

Thinking about what to say in a conversation.

5

Reflecting on a past experience.

Encouraging oneself before a public presentation.

Importance

Develops self-awareness and emotional intelligence.

Helps in goal setting and personal motivation.

Crucial for decision-making and self-improvement.

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN ORAL AND WRITTEN COMMUNICATION

One of the most significant differences between face-to face (oral) and written communication is that the immediate feedback present in oral communication is not present in written communication. Since feedback is very important in communication, delayed feedback which happens in written communication, can cause misunderstanding, thereby affecting effective communication. Another difference is that written communication has a permanency which is missing in oral communication.

ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES OF VERBAL COMMUNICATIONS

METHODS

Written Verbal Communication (Letters, Memos, Reports, Minutes of meetings, Articles, Press-release)

Advantages

- i. Provides written records and evidence of dispatch and receipt.
- ii. Capable of relaying complex ideas.
- iii. Provides analysis, evaluation, and summary.
- iv. Disseminates information to dispersed receiver.

- v. Can confirm, interpret, and clarify oral communication.
- vi. Forms basis of contract or agreement.

Disadvantages

- i. Can take time to produce.
- ii. Can be expensive.
- iii. Tends to be more formal and distant.

6

- iv. Instant feedback is not possible.
- v. Difficult to modify message once dispatched.
- vi. Does not allow for immediate exchange of opinions, views or attitudes.

Oral Verbal Communication (Face-to-face conversation, Interview, Meeting, Oral briefing, Public address, Oral presentation, Telephone call, Conference, Training session)

Advantages

- i. Direct medium of communication.
- ii. Advantages of physical proximity and usually includes both sight and sound of sender and receiver.
- iii. Instant interchange of opinions, views, attitudes.
- iv. Instantaneous feedback.
- v. Easier to convince or persuade.
- vi. Allows for contribution and participation from all present.
- vii. Inexpensive.

Disadvantages

- i. More difficult to hold ground in face of opposition.
- ii. More difficult to control when a number of people take part.
- iii. Lack of time to think things through.
- iv. Quality of decision-making may be inferior.
- v. Sometimes disputes result over what was agreed.

THE PROCESS OF COMMUNICATION

Communication is fundamentally a process, that is, a dynamic, continuous flow of information and interaction between people. It involves several interrelated steps and elements working together to ensure that a message is sent, received, understood, and acted upon.

What is a Process?

A process is a series of actions or steps taken to achieve a particular end. Communication is not a one-time act but an ongoing cycle or process. The communication process is relatively simple and divided into three basic components. It is not just a single action but a chain of several

7

interdependent actions. Essentially, the communication process involves actions, reactions, and interactions.

Actions: this refers to the initiative taken by someone (a sender) or an encoder to share information, observation, or opinion with others. He may do so by speaking, writing, drawing, or gesturing.

Reaction: this is a response to the action taken by the sender. In other words, the person addressed (receiver) responds to the sender's initiative of starting the communication. Depending on the type of response given, we are able to determine whether or not the receiver is willing to be party to the communication encounter.

Interaction: this is primarily concerned with the exchange of messages between the sender and receiver. If the receiver is willing to participate, he sends his response to the initiator.

The responses may be verbal or non-verbal. An interaction may involve two or more persons provided those who take part in the encounter share common experiences, codes or symbols. There will be a continuous exchange among them as long as there is information to share or ideas and thought to put across.

Understanding communication as a process helps us see it as more than just speaking or writing. It's an interactive and purposeful exchange, where each step contributes to the effectiveness of the message. Recognizing the process allows us to identify and fix breakdowns in communication.

ACTION

REACTION

INTERACTION

8

ELEMENTS OF COMMUNICATION

- i. **Stimulus-** this is the situation (the happening) that starts or sets the communication in motion. This is basically the reason one has for communicating which may be to inform, educate, advise, scold, entertain, e.t.c.
- ii. **The Encoder/Source/Sender-** this is the individual, group or organization who begins the communication or conversation. The source is the initiator because he begins the communication process. As the source or encoder, he packages the message in a way that it can be communicated. When encoding a message, the sender has to begin by deciding what to transmit or send out. It is important for the source or encoder to use symbols familiar to the intended receiver, otherwise there will be miscommunication.
- iii. **The Message-** this is the intention, idea, feeling, knowledge, opinion, information, or thought sent across to the receiver. In a communication situation, the message is the sum total of all that the source/encoder desires to pass across to the decoder or receiver. When we speak, the speech is the message. When we gesture, the movements of our arms, the expressions on our faces are the message.
- iv. **The Channel-** to send or transmit a message, the sender uses some kind of channel (also known as a medium). The channel is the means by which we transfer the

message from the sender to the receiver and from the receiver back to the sender. The channel could be oral, written, or non-verbal. Common channels include the telephone and a variety of written forms such as reports, letter and memos. The channel must be right if the message must be delivered effectively. If the sender uses an inappropriate channel, his message may not reach the intended recipients/receivers.

v. The Decoder/Receiver- the decoder is the receiver of the message. He is the target audience for the message. All the source/sender's effort to communicate is to inform or affect the attitude of the receiver. That is why communication must be receiver-centered. For communication to be effective and successful, the receiver must correctly interpret the sender's message.

9

vi. Feedback- this is the reaction that the receiver gives to the message. The receiver may agree or disagree. The feedback may be verbal or non-verbal; it can also be written or oral. Communication is incomplete without feedback. It confirms that the message is well received and understood. Feedback guides the source in the communication process and helps him to know when to alter or modify his message if not properly received. Feedback is positive when it shows that the message has been well received and understood and it could be negative when it shows that the intended effect has not been achieved.

Effective communication is crucial (important) for building relationships, fostering understanding, resolving conflicts, making informed decisions, and collaborating successfully in various aspects of life, including personal, professional, and social interactions. It requires both parties to be actively engaged in the process, listening carefully and ensuring that the intended message is conveyed accurately.

Miscommunication can lead to misunderstandings, confusion and even conflict. To avoid this, it is very important to communicate clearly and effectively.

The Determinants of Communication Effectiveness

Effective communication is essential (important) to the success of any organization, as well as other human relationships. Communication can be described as a two-way street, therefore both the person communicating and the one being communicated to has to participate. The success of a communication or a conversation relies on both the source and the receiver. It is important to understand the key factors that enhance or hinder effectiveness in communication.

The key factors that determine effective communication are:

- i. Communication skills- there are five verbal communication skills. Two of these are encoding skills (speaking and writing). Two of them are decoding skills (reading and listening). The fifth one is important for both encoding and decoding (reasoning). The more developed the communication skills of the communicators are, the more their chances of communicating effectively.
- ii. Attitude- the attitude of the sender affects the way in which he communicates. A

positive attitude produces positive results, while a negative attitude produces negative
10

results. A positive, open-minded attitude is key to good communication. When people are positive and open minded, they are more likely to be able to see things from the other person's perspective and understand where they are coming from. They are also more likely to be willing to listen and consider different points of view. On the other hand, a negative attitude can make it difficult to communicate effectively. If a person is close minded, they may not be willing to listen or consider new ideas. This can lead to misunderstanding and conflict.

iii. Knowledge level- the amount of knowledge that the sender/source has about his subject matter/topic/content, will affect his message. This is because one cannot communicate what he/she does not know, therefore to communicate with maximum effectiveness; the sender must have a good knowledge of the content he wants to communicate.

iv. Socio-cultural system- Social-cultural systems significantly influence communication effectiveness by shaping how individuals perceive, interpret, and engage in communication. These systems include the values, norms, belief, customs, and practices that are prevalent within a particular society or cultural group. Understanding these socio-cultural factors is crucial for effective communication especially in diverse or cross-cultural interactions. A sender/source's message is influenced by his socio-cultural system, the groups he belongs to, his social class, his values and standards, his perception, all affect the way he communicates. The way a receiver receives and interprets messages, is also influenced by his socio-cultural system.

To communicate effectively, you must develop yourself in the above listed areas. These same factors affect the receiver in communication. Note that the most important element in any communication situation is the receiver. The receiver must be kept in mind if there must be an effective communication, for if your receiver does not understand you, you have not communicated effectively.

NOISE IN COMMUNICATION

Noise is interference (barrier) that keeps a message from being understood or accurately interpreted. It is a potent (strong) barrier to effective communication. Noise may be in different forms.

11

i. Physical noise- this comes from the environment and keeps the message from being heard and understood. It may be from loud conversations, side talks at meetings, vehicular sounds, sound from work men's tool, e.t.c.

ii. Psychological noise- this comes from within as a result of poor mental attitude, depression, emotional stress, personal bias against the speaker e.t.c.

iii. Linguistic noise- this comes from the sender/source's inability to understand the

language of communication accurately and appropriately. It may be a grammatical noise manifested in form of defects in the use of the rules of grammar of a language, and faulty sentence structure. It may be semantic as in wrong use of words or use of unfamiliar words, misspellings, e.t.c. it could also be phonological manifested in incorrect pronunciation.

iv. Physiological noise- this is from interference from the body in form of bodily discomforts, feeling of hunger and tiredness, poor hearing, stammering or stuttering, effects of medications, eye defects or other mental or emotional disabilities.

THE PURPOSE OF COMMUNICATION

Why do we communicate?

The purpose of communication is our reason for communication. What do we wish to achieve when we communicate?

Communication

↓ _____ ↓ _____ ↓

Inform Persuade Entertain

Communication to Inform- this involves passing on information to an audience with the intention of educating or imparting knowledge. Informative messages can be used to give instructions and information on codes, steps and procedures in work places, e.t.c.

Communication to persuade- Persuasion is an attempt to influence people's beliefs, attitudes, intentions and behavior in relation to an event, idea, object or persons. Persuasion is achieved

12

through written or spoken communication that conveys information, thoughts, emotions, logic and arguments.

Communication to entertain- this is another aim of communication. Communication can be used for entertainment to stimulate the socialization of individuals in society. This can be done through literature/drama.

Note that in looking at the purpose of communication, it is very important for the sender/encoder to consider the response he desires to get from the receiver.

THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN COMMUNICATION AND LANGUAGE

What is Language?

Language can be defined as a code for communication.

Can communication take place without language?

Language is the primary tool for communication. It is a structured system of symbols and rules used to convey messages. Without language, communication would be limited to non-verbal cues. Language enhances clarity, specificity, and understanding in communication.

Language is a dominant factor in communication, there is no communication without language. It is with the help of language that we communicate, whether orally (speech), written (letters) or gesture (as in signs). Language then is a code with which we encode our messages and through

which the messages are decoded by the receivers. Note that Language and Communication are like Siamese twins (joined together), one is not possible without the other. If we must communicate effectively, we must have a good command of language.

COMMUNICATION PROBLEMS

i. Limitation to the receiver's capacity- there can be a breakdown in communication if the receiver does not have the capacity to understand the sender's message. this can be as a result of the receiver's academic background, intelligence level or his level of reasoning.

ii. Noise- this includes any external or internal factor that interferes with the reception of messages. Noise could be physical, physiological, psychological or linguistic. When

13

there is noise in the communication process, the effectiveness of communication is hindered.

iii. Misunderstanding- when the receiver does not understand the sender's message, there is bound to be misunderstanding, and consequently, communication would be ineffective. Ensure to use clear and simply terms or words in communicating so that your receiver will understand you.

iv. Disagreement- when the receiver does not agree with the sender's view, there is the tendency to read a different interpretation to the sender's message.

THE IMPACT OF MOTHER TONGUE INTERFERENCE ON COMMUNICATION

The concept of Mother tongue Interference

A language that is learnt and acquired from an individual's environment as he grows is called first language, mother tongue or L1. If this person has cause to learn another language later in life, this is called second language or L2. Mother tongue Interference is said to take place if L1 influences L2. Mother tongue Interference, therefore, is the trace left by someone's native language upon the foreign language he is trying to acquire. Mother tongue interference, also known as language transfer, occurs when the structure, sounds, or usage rules of a speaker's first language (L1) negatively affect their use of a second language (L2). In Nigeria, this most often refers to how indigenous Nigerian languages influence the learning and usage of English, which is the country's official language and a major medium of instruction.

Levels of Mother tongue interference

Phonological Level- phonological interference occurs when due to the speech sounds of L1 certain sounds of L2 cannot be pronounced or are wrongly pronounced. This happens mostly as a result of differences in sound systems (phonology) of languages or dialects. When speakers of different languages or dialects interact, differences in their pronunciations, accents or intonations can lead to communication challenges. Phonological interference can cause linguistic noise which can lead to breakdown in communication. Nigerian languages do not have all the phonemes (sounds) of English, so speakers often substitute difficult English sounds with familiar local ones.

Examples:

14

/θ/ → /t/: "think" pronounced as "tink"

/ʃ/ → /s/: "she" pronounced as "see"

/z/ → /s/: "zoo" pronounced as "soo"

Semantic interference- this occurs when due to L1, certain words are misused and wrong meanings given to them. This occurs when a word from the mother tongue is used with a meaning that does not correspond exactly in English. Semantic interference in communication also refers to misunderstandings or confusion that arises from the meanings of words, phrases, or symbols within a message. This type of interference occurs when the sender and the receiver of a message assign different meanings to the same word or phrase, leading to misinterpretation. Semantic interference can make it difficult to understand the actual meaning of words that are being said. For example, if someone uses a lot of slangs, it can be difficult to understand what they are saying.

Syntactic interference- this occurs when due to the interference of L1, the sentence pattern (SVOA in English) is disrupted. Syntactic interference in communication refers to misunderstandings or confusion that arises due to differences in the structure of grammar (syntax) of languages. Syntax involves the rules and patterns that govern how words are combined to form sentences and convey meaning. When speakers of different languages or dialects communicate, differences in syntactic structures can lead to errors or misinterpretations that can affect clarity and effectiveness of communication. Local language structures may influence how English sentences are constructed.

Examples:

"She is having two brothers" instead of "She has two brothers"

"He come yesterday" instead of "He came yesterday"

"The girl beautiful" instead of "The girl is beautiful"

CODE SWITCHING/CODE MIXING/DISSONANCE

A code is a system of sounds, symbols or signs used by a group of people to communicate with one another. A speaker could choose a code that his audience understands to communicate with

15

them. In other words, to pass information or messages to the listeners, the speaker should select a language they know.

Code Mixing- this is the use of two or more languages by a bilingual (a person who knows and speaks two languages) or a multilingual (a person who knows and speaks more than two languages), interchangeably in the same speech, social situation, or communication event. This statement indicates that the speaker combines two or more languages in an utterance. The languages are used within the same utterance, spoken or written, with an audience who understands them.

Examples:

Please pass me the cup of ruwan sanyi. (Hausa/English Language)

I need to gozie him for helping me. (Igbo and English language)

I am feeling very tired, let me sun (sleep). (Yoruba and English language)

Code switching- this is the switch from one language to another by a speaker in a single conversation. This occurs when speakers switch back and forth between two or more languages or language varieties in the context of a single conversation or utterance. When people speak more than one language, they can switch from one language to another while communicating. When the speaker makes the first utterance in a particular language, he may decide to make the next utterance in another language. Code switching shows proficiency and competence. This phenomenon often occurs in multilingual communities where speakers switch languages based on the social context, the people they are communicating with, or the topic of discussion.

In Nigeria, speakers often switch between English and indigenous languages like Hausa, Igbo, Yoruba, or Nigerian Pidgin, especially in informal conversations or when emphasizing a point.

Examples:

I will see you tomorrow, insha Allah. (English to Hausa/Arabic expression)

I will call you later. Kedu ka I di, I hope you are fine? (Igbo/English language)

We have finished the project. Amma zan tafi yanzu, see you next week. (Hausa/ English Language)

16

I am going to the market. I will buy eja ati amala for dinner. (Yoruba/English language)

Our lecturer said the exam will be tough. Me I don dey pray already. (English/Pidgin)

The difference between Code mixing and Code switching is that while code mixing involves the blending of words or phrases from different languages within the same sentence, often to convey meaning more naturally or precisely, code switching involves changing languages between sentences or clauses, reflecting a shift in context or audience.

Dissonance in communication occurs when there's a conflict or contradiction in communication, such as between verbal and non-verbal cues, or when the message contradicts the audience's beliefs, emotions, or expectations. This can occur when the verbal message (what is said) and the nonverbal cues (such as tone, body language, or facial expressions) do not align, or when the message being communicated is in conflict with the beliefs, values, or expectation of the receiver. For example, if someone says they are fine but their body language suggests they are upset, this creates dissonance in communication. The receiver of the message may feel confused or distrustful because the verbal and nonverbal messages are contradictory. Dissonance in communication can lead to misunderstandings, reduced credibility, and difficulty in building trust. For communication to be effective, ensure that verbal messages are consistent with nonverbal cues and that they are aligned with the expectations and beliefs of the receiver(s).

Examples:

A mother shouts “I’m not angry!” while yelling and banging the table.

A lecturer says “You are all brilliant students,” while frowning and shaking his head.

A student tells a lecturer “I respect you sir” while rolling their eyes.

17

ORAL ENGLISH

Oral English refers to the spoken aspect of the English language. It focuses on the correct pronunciation of sounds, proper articulation of words, the use of stress and intonation, and effective communication in spoken form.

Organs of Speech

The organs of speech are the parts of the human body involved in producing speech. They include: (Lips, Teeth, Tongue, Alveolar ridge, Hard palate, Soft palate (velum), Uvula, Glottis, Vocal cords, Nasal cavity, Oral cavity, Lungs, Diaphragm)

These organs work together to produce and articulate sounds.

Phonemes of English

Phonemes are the smallest units of sound in a language that can differentiate meaning. There are 44 phonemes in the English language; it is from them that countless number of English sounds can be formed. The phonemes are divided into 24 consonant sounds and 20 vowel sounds (12 pure vowels and 8 diphthongs).

Consonant Sounds

Consonants are speech sounds produced when airflow is obstructed in some way by the articulatory organs (lips, teeth, tongue, palate). There are 24 consonant sounds in English.

1. /p/- pen, top, paper, people, apple
2. /b/ - back, big, baby, table, club
3. /t/- time, top, water, later, bat
4. /d/ - dog, do, dance, hard, bed
5. /k/ - cat, back, cook, class, king
6. /g/ - go, good, get, bag, game
7. /f/- fan, fish, leaf, coffee, phone

18

8. /v/ - van, very, love, move, oven
9. /θ/ - think, three, bath, both, thank
10. /ð/ - this, that, mother, breathe, though
11. /s/ - see, sun, kiss, pass, sister
12. /z/- zoo, buzz, is, prize, lazy
13. /ʃ/ - she, shop, crash, nation, sure
14. /ʒ/- measure, vision, television, pleasure, genre

15. /tʃ/ – chip, chin, match, teacher, watch
16. /dʒ/ – jam, judge, large, edge, ginger
17. /m/ – man, mother, time, room, come
18. /n/ – no, not, name, ten, dinner
19. /ŋ/ – sing, long, song, king, bringing
20. /l/ – love, let, tell, little, bell
21. /r/ – red, right, very, arrive, around
22. /j/ – yes, yellow, young, you, use
23. /w/ – we, wet, what, win, window
24. /h/ – hat, hope, house, hello, hot

Vowel Sounds

Vowels are speech sounds made without any significant constriction of airflow. They are 20 in number and are divided into pure vowels and diphthongs. The pure vowels are 12 in number comprising 5 long vowels, and 7 short ones, while the diphthongs are 8 in number.

Monophthongs (12)

19

1. /i:/ – sheep, seat, meet, machine, please
2. /ɪ/ – ship, sit, bid, middle, little
3. /e/ – bed, pen, said, head, ready
4. /æ/ – cat, man, bat, apple, back
5. /ʌ/ – cup, love, sun, luck, mother
6. /ɑ:/ – car, father, heart, part, start
7. /ɒ/ – hot, clock, dog, long, not *(mainly British)*
8. /ɔ:/ – call, four, law, door, talk
9. /ʊ/ – book, good, put, full, look
10. /u:/ – boot, moon, school, food, true
11. /ɜ:/ – bird, girl, learn, word, nurse
12. /ə/ – about, teacher, banana, ago, problem (schwa – weak vowel)

Diphthongs (8)

13. /eɪ/ – face, day, say, break, rain
14. /aɪ/ – my, fly, time, try, right
15. /ɔɪ/ – boy, toy, coin, enjoy, oil
16. /aʊ/ – now, how, out, loud, shout
17. /əʊ/ – no, go, home, road, open *(British)*
18. /ɪə/ – ear, beer, idea, near, cheer

19. /eə/ – air, care, share, dare, parent

20. /ʊə/ – pure, sure, cure, tourist, endure

20

Stress

Stress refers to the emphasis placed on certain syllables or words during speech. A syllable is a unit of pronunciation having one vowel sound, with or without surrounding consonants, forming the whole or part of a word. Stress is the sound difference achieved by pronouncing one syllable more forcefully than another. A stressed syllable is louder, longer, and said with a higher pitch than an unstressed one. Stress can simply be defined as the force with which a syllable is pronounced. Stress can change the meaning of words, for example, REcord (Noun), and reCORD (verb). We do not stress every syllable, and we do not stress consonants.

Types of Stress:

i. Word Stress: Emphasis on a particular syllable within a word.

`Table` (not taBLE)

`PREsent` (noun) vs pre`SENT` (verb)

Word stress can sometimes change not only the pronunciation, but also the meaning, and the grammatical classes of words. When a word has both a noun and a verb form, the noun is stressed on the first syllable, while the verb is stressed on the second syllable.

Examples

NOUNS VERBS

PROgress Progress

Record reCORD

PREsent Present

Object Object

CONduct Conduct

PROduce proDUCE

PERmit Permit

CONtract Contract

CONflict Conflict

21

CONtest Contest

CONvert Convert

SUSpect Suspect

EXtract exTRACT

COMbat comBAT

PROtest proTEST

Import Import

Export Export

SUBject Subject

Rules of Word Stress:

i. Monosyllabic words (one syllable words): they are usually stressed.

Example: dog, run, sit, play, kind e.t.c.

ii. Disyllabic (two-syllable) nouns/adjectives: stressed usually on the first syllable

Examples: TABLE, DOCTOR, Happy, FARMER,

iii. Disyllabic (two-syllable) verbs: stressed on the second syllable

Examples: reLAX, aRRIVE, deCIDE, inSIST, reDEEM e.t.c

iv. Compound nouns: stressed on the first word

Examples: BLACKboard, FOOTball

v. Compound adjectives/verbs: stressed on the second word

Examples: old-FASHioned, underSTAND

ii. Sentence Stress:

Certain words in a sentence (usually content words like nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs) are stressed, while grammatical words (e.g., articles, prepositions) are unstressed.

Example

She bought a new car yesterday.

22

(Stressed words: bought, new, car)

Intonation

Intonation is the variation in pitch while speaking. It can show emotions, attitudes, grammatical functions (like asking a question), or emphasis.

Types of Intonation Patterns

i. Falling Intonation (↘)

This is generally used for statements, commands, Interjections/exclamations, and WH-questions.

Examples:

i. Statements: She is coming.

ii. WH-questions: What is your name?

iii. Commands: Get out of my room.

iv. Interjections/exclamations: How nice of you to have remembered me!

ii. Rising Intonation (↗)

Used for yes/no questions, surprise, or to show uncertainty.

Examples

i. Are you ready?

ii. Is it raining?

iii. Really?

iv. He stole the money?

23

CORRESPONDENCE

What is correspondence?

Correspondence often refers to the exchange of letters or written messages between individuals or organizations. It can be formal or informal and may be conducted through traditional mail (letter writing) or electronic means like email.

Types of Correspondence

Letters- Letter writing is very vital in everyday life. Letter writing is specifically divided into two types. They are: Informal or friendly letters, and Formal or business letters such as job application letter, request letter, recommendation letter, social or invitation letter, letter of complaints, memos, cover letter, e.t.c

Memo- A memo or memorandum is a type of business document that is used to communicate information within an organization. Memos are typically brief and to the point, and they usually follow a standard format. The memo should include a heading that states the purpose of the memo, followed by a body that contains the main points of the message. The memo should also include a closing that states the writer's name and contact. A well written memo is informative and concise.

Circular – These are letters or documents distributed to a group of people to provide information or instructions. They are ideal for disseminating information to a broad audience, such as employees or members of an organization. Circulars can be used to announce events, share policies or procedures, or provide updates on current activities.

Notices- A notice is a short and formal announcement or advertisement that informs or reminds people of something. Notices are frequently used to announce meetings, deadlines, or important events. Notices are short and concise, and are designed to communicate specific information promptly and efficiently. A notice is used when many people in the organization have to be given the same information. It is short and the language is simple.

24

The Differences between formal and informal letters

Informal Letters

Informal letters are the letters we write to our friends, relatives, parents, siblings, acquaintances and to other contemporaries.

Features of an informal letter

- i. It must be conversational in tone and simple.
- ii. It is chatty: That is, the writer opens his mind freely and discusses some personal issues with the receiver.
- iii. The language must be familiar, with the use of colloquialisms, and slang. The slang to be used must not be abusive. Note that slang is not used when a younger person writes to his elders. There must be a wary use of slang and colloquial expressions.
- iv. Short and contracted form of language is obligatory. Examples: you'd, isn't, can't,

I'm, you've, e.t.c. All these short forms of expressions make the informal letters sound fully informal.

Formal Letters

These are correspondences documented for exchanging official information. That is, they are letters meant for offices and other official purposes. Formal letters include;

Letters to organizations:

Applying for jobs

Making requests

Making recommendations

Cover letters for curriculum vitae

Placing orders

Invitations, Memos, Circulars

25

Letters to institutions asking for permission and making complaints

Features of a Formal Letter

- i. Clarity- A formal letter must give clear information.
- ii. Conciseness- A good formal letter must be straight to the point. Avoid the use of irrelevant expressions. Choose your words properly.
- iii. Formal Tone- Formal letters maintain a formal and professional tone throughout the communication. The language used is polite and devoid of casual or informal expressions.
- iv. Formal Greetings and Closing- Formal letters begin with a formal salutation, and closes with a polite and respectful closing phrases (Yours sincerely or Yours faithfully), followed by the sender's signature and name.
- v. No abbreviations or slangs are used in formal letters.

Parts of a Letter

Informal Letters

The address- The only address required in an informal letter is the writer's address. Each word in the address must start with a capital letter. Your address may be written either in block or punctuated style or slant and unpunctuated style.

Examples:

Block or Punctuated:

Petroleum Training Institute,

P.M.B 20,

Effurun,

Delta State.

6th September, 2023.

Slant or Unpunctuated style:

26

Petroleum Training Institute

P.M.B 20

Effurun

Delta State

6th September 2023

Date- This should be written on the line following the last line of the address. It is always preferable to write your date clearly in both figures and letters. Avoid writing your date in figures only. This is to avoid ambiguity. 06/09/2023 in British English is 6th September 2023, while in American English it is June 9th 2023. Any of these forms is correct:

12 October, 2012.

October 12, 2012.

12th October, 2012.

Also note the comma after the month and the full stop after the year. Avoid using abbreviations for months.

Salutation/Opening Greeting- Your salutation/opening greeting must slant from the margin on the left side of your writing paper, on the line immediately after the date. Examples: Dear Dad, Dear Mom, Dear Ugo (Note that it is wrong to just write Dear friend in Informal letters without mentioning the name of your friend).

Introductory Paragraph- In the first paragraph, the welfare of the recipient should be enquired after. The writer should also express his own welfare to the recipient. Your introductory paragraph must be void of clichés and slangs like “I hope you’re really swimming in the ocean of good health”. Instead make your expressions simple and clear like “I hope you’re sound in health?”

Body of the letter- In this part, the main topic of the letter should be introduced in detail. Though chatty language and other colloquial expressions are welcomed in informal letters, the expressions to be used must be acceptable and appropriate for the letters. For instance, when

27

writing to adult relations, or even your parents, the language should be censored, some respect should be shown.

Conclusion- Your conclusion should indicate that your conversation is really coming to a close. All this point, send your regards only to those known to both of you.

Complimentary close- Your complimentary close should be intentionally intimate just as the salutation. This is to maintain a cordial relationship or familiarity with the recipient. The following expressions can be used in the complimentary close: ‘Yours affectionately’, ‘Yours ever’, ‘Your loving son/daughter’. Note ‘Yours’ starts with capital Y. Any other word following the letter must be written in small letter. There is no apostrophe either before or after S in yours.

The last word in the complimentary close goes with a comma. After this, your first name or nickname (especially letter to a friend) is written. There must be a full stop at the end of your name.

Formal Letters

Writer's address----this appears on the top right-hand corner of the writing paper. The writer's address is the origin of the letter and must never be omitted.

Date----- This follows immediately after the writer's address. Make sure to write the month in word.

The recipient's designation (title)---- E.g The Director, The Principal, The Manager, The Chairman.

The recipient's address---- This should be written on the left-hand corner of the letter.

Salutation or Greeting-----Dear Sir or Madam; this expression is used when you do not know the name of the person you are writing to. Dear Mr. Mohammed; this type of expression is used when you know the name of the recipient. Use these titles in this case Mr, Mrs, Miss, Ms, Dr etc and the surname only. If you are writing to a woman and you do not know if she uses Mrs or Miss, you can use Ms, which stands for both married and single women.

Heading----- this can either be written in block or small letters. It is underlined if written in small letters and not underlined if written in block letters. The title tells the reader in clear terms what the letter is about. It should be short and straight to the point.

28

Body-----this contains the full information contained in the letter.

Complimentary close---this includes; 'Yours faithfully', used to end your official letter when you do not know the name of the person you are writing to, 'Yours sincerely', used when the salutation is done by addressing the recipient by the name, and Your signature; always append your signature and then write your name beneath your signature.

Note that the tone of a formal letter must be strictly formal. There should be no room to exchange pleasantries, jokes, chatty and colloquial expressions. It should be precise, direct and business minded. Moreover, the language should be as polite and official as possible, while informal letters can be more casual and may use slang or colloquial language.

29

Formal letter sample

100 Boundary Road,

Benin-city,

Edo State,

31st August, 2025.

Jahad Construction Ltd,

P.O.Box 1069,

Osogbo,

Osun State.

Dear Sir,

APPLICATION FOR THE POSITION OF A CIVIL ENGINEER

I write to apply for the position of a civil Engineer as advertised in the 22nd July 2023 edition of the Sun Newspaper.

I graduated from the University of Nigeria in 2019 with a second class upper division in civil and structural Engineering.

The enclosed CV demonstrates my significant experience in overseeing a wide range of civil engineering projects, including roads, bridges and sewer systems. I can plan, design and oversee construction effectively. In addition, the projects that I have undertaken have honed my skills in building strong working relationships with clients, and ensuring a quality process from start to finish. I am able to supervise the design of new projects as well as review and improve existing structures and I have provided examples of these in my CV.

I would welcome the opportunity to tell you how my skills and experience would be an asset to your organization and I am available for an interview at any time.

Thank you for your consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Signature

Name

30

Informal letter sample

Petroleum Training Institute,

P.M.B 20,

Effurun,

Delta State,

Nigeria.

31st August, 2025.

My dear Kenny,

Many thanks for your interesting letter which I received last week. How about your mum, Dad and Juliet? I hope Juliet has returned from the boarding school? I really miss all of you. Ejiro my younger brother is also expressing his heartfelt regards to you all.

I learnt from the last letter you wrote me that your school will be closing for the Christmas holidays on the 12th of December. I will be very glad if you spend the holiday with us at Yankari, Bauchi State. After a long hectic life in the city, I am sure you will really feel happy in this part of the world. The rural environment will add splendor and succor to your mind and energise you more for serious life over there in Ireland. The Yankari game reserves and Wuse lake are special attractions here. Apart from these, my parents have been getting everything

ready in welcoming you. You can trust the hospitable nature of my dear mum. In fact, she has promised to prepare Ukodo, your favourite food, to celebrate your arrival. Besides, Miky, Tinu and Chuzy are all warming up to give you a warm welcome. All our family members will be very glad to have you with us. Please do come quickly; we are dearly waiting for you.

Your loving friend,

Tega

31

COMPREHENSION AND INTERPRETATION

Comprehension is an important language and communication skill. It refers to the ability to read, understand, and interpret written texts. It involves decoding the literal meaning of words and grasping the implied or figurative meanings. Interpretation goes a step further, it involves analyzing the message, making inferences, drawing conclusions, and understanding the writer's tone, purpose, and techniques.

In comprehension passages, the ability to identify the major or the topic sentence in a paragraph or in a passage is very important. The topic sentence usually gives an insight or a picture of what is being said in the passage. It also indicates the subject matter of the passage. At times, the topic sentence comes first in the passage. However, it can come at the middle or even at end of the passage, but a critical reading of the passage will reveal to you where the topic sentence is located in the passage.

Points to note in understanding comprehension

1. Read the questions first to know what is demanded of you, this is very vital during examination to avoid unnecessary waste of time.
2. Read the passage carefully.
3. When you come across words that you are not familiar with, interpret them in the context in which they are used in the passage.
4. Ensure that your answers are what the passage is talking about.
5. Be watchful of signal words and phrases.
6. Distinguish between key points and supporting details.
7. Focus on key words or any word that is emphasized in the passage.
8. Things to avoid in answering comprehension questions
9. Do not misinterpret or deviate from the question.
10. Giving of two or more answers to more answers to a question should be avoided, excepted where stated.
11. Avoid giving your answers in single words or phrases, unless otherwise stated. Answers should be written in sentences.
12. When asked to give the synonyms or antonyms of words, do not use words that go out of context. The word must fit perfectly to substitute the one given in the passage.

32

13. Never overlook the instruction to any question.

14. Avoid repeating answers unnecessarily.

15. Do not copy back the question before answering it. It is a waste of time but make sure you number your answers well.

Skills Involved in Comprehension and Interpretation

i. Identifying Main Ideas in a Given Passage

The main idea is the central thought or message the writer wants to convey. It is usually found in the topic sentence, often the first or last sentence of a paragraph.

Strategies

Skim through the passage.

Look for repeated concepts or terms.

Ask: "What is this paragraph mostly about?"

Example

"Although Nigeria has diverse ethnic groups, unity can be achieved through mutual understanding."

Main Idea: Unity in Nigeria can be achieved through mutual understanding.

ii. Differentiating the Main Ideas from the Details in a Passage

Main ideas are general statements, while supporting details explain, illustrate, or provide evidence for the main idea. Details can be facts, examples, statistics, or anecdotes.

Tip: Ask, "Is this sentence essential to understanding the whole paragraph, or does it just support something more important?"

iii. Using the Main Idea to Anticipate Specific Details in a Passage

Once you understand the main idea, you can predict the type of details that will follow. This skill is useful during reading exams or academic study.

Example: If a paragraph begins with "Social media has both positive and negative effects," expect specific details on both benefits and drawbacks.

iv. Using Context Clues to Aid Comprehension

33

Context clues help readers infer the meaning of unfamiliar words. Types include:

Definition

Synonym

Antonym

Example

Inference

Example: "She is very meticulous, always paying attention to the smallest details." The word 'meticulous', means careful or precise.

v. Identifying Relationship Patterns of Ideas in a Passage

Look for transitions and signal words to identify patterns:

Comparison: similarly, likewise

Contrast: however, although

Cause and effect: because, therefore

Chronology: first, then, next

Enumeration: firstly, secondly

vi. Using Context Clues such as Definitions, Restatements, and Examples to Derive Meaning

Writers often restate difficult words using simpler expressions.

Example: "The child was elated, that is, extremely happy."

Example: "Various artifacts, such as pottery and tools, were found at the site."

vii. Explaining How Affixes Modify Meanings

Affixes are word parts added to base words to change meaning.

Prefixes: added to the beginning (e.g., un-, re-, pre-)

Suffixes: added to the end (e.g., -ment, -ness, -tion)

Examples:

happy - unhappy (prefix "un-" shows negation)

develop - development (suffix "-ment" forms a noun)

viii. Interpreting Figurative Language in a Passage

34

Figurative language includes similes, metaphors, personification, hyperbole, etc.

Examples:

"Time is a thief." Time passes quickly and steals moments.

"She cried a river." She cried a lot.

ix. Drawing Conclusions from Available Information

Conclusions are informed judgments based on the information provided. This involves inference, critical thinking, and logical reasoning.

Example: If the passage says, "The ground was wet and dark clouds loomed," we can conclude that it had recently rained or was about to rain.

35

Paper 2 of 2 — GNS 102

Level ND1 • Second Semester • Handout

GNS 102 NOTES

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COMMUNICATION

What is Communication?

Communication is the process of exchanging information, ideas, thoughts or feelings between individuals or groups. It is an essential aspect of human interaction and it plays a vital role in conveying (transferring) thoughts, emotions and intentions. Communication can occur through various channels such as spoken or written language, gestures (signaling with any part of the body especially the head or hand, to express an idea or meaning.), facial expressions, and even through visual or auditory signals. Communication is innate, that means everyone is born with the ability to communicate. Babies learn to communicate by crying, kicking and smiling.

Frank Hartman defines communication as “Control of behaviour through descriptive and reinforcing stimuli”. Hartman implies that an attempt at communication is an attempt at controlling the behaviour of people.

Descriptive and

COMMUNICATION CONTROL OF BEHAVIOUR

Reinforcing Stimuli

Chappel and Read define communication as “any means by which thought is transferred from one person to another”. Here, we see communication involving at least two persons. This implies that there is an individual who attempts through whatever means to transfer thought to another person.

1

According to Goyer 1989, communication is an occurrence involving a minimum of four sequential ingredients: (1) a generator of a (2) sign-symbol which is (3) projected to (4) at least one receiver who assigns meanings.

A GENERATOR SIGN SYMBOLS PROJECTED TO A RECEIVER

According to Keyton 2011, Communication can be defined as the process of transmitting information and common understanding from one person to another.

Coates 2009 gave three simple definitions of communication as:

Communication is the sharing of information.

Communication is the giving and receiving of messages.

Communication is the transfer of information from one or more people to one or more people.

De Vito 1986 explains Communication as the process of transmitting a message from a sender to a receiver through a channel and with the interference of noise.

Note that Communication is not just the giving of information; it is the giving of understandable information, and the receiving, and understanding of the message. Ultimately, for the purpose of this course, we may define communication as a goal oriented process, by which messages are passed from sources to receivers through adequate channels.

GOAL MESSAGES FROM TO THROUGH

ORIENTED ARE SOURCES RECEIVERS ADEQUATE

→ → → →

PROCESS PASSED CHANNELS

2

METHODS OF COMMUNICATION

There are basically two broad methods of communication; Verbal, and Non-verbal.

Communication can further be categorized into Inter-personal and Intra-personal communication.

Verbal Communication

Verbal communication refers to the use of spoken or written words to convey a message. It is the most direct form of communication and is commonly used in both formal and informal settings.

Types of Verbal Communication:

Oral Verbal Communication: Includes face-to-face conversations, telephone calls, lectures, speeches, and interviews.

Written Verbal Communication: Includes emails, letters, reports, text messages, articles, and books.

Key Features of Verbal Communication

It requires a shared language between the sender and receiver.

It allows for immediate feedback (especially in spoken form).

It can be formal or informal.

It is structured and can be documented (in written form).

Examples of Verbal Communication

A lecturer explaining a topic to students.

A manager writing an email to staff.

A news anchor reporting on television.

Importance of Verbal Communication

Facilitates clarity and accuracy.

Helps in effective teaching, learning, and workplace interaction.

Supports official and legal documentation.

3

Non-Verbal Communication

Non-verbal communication is the transmission of messages without the use of words. It includes

gestures, facial expressions, body posture, eye contact, tone of voice, and use of space (proxemics).

Components of Non-Verbal Communication:

Kinesics: Body movement such as gestures, facial expressions, posture.

Paralanguage: Tone, pitch, and speed of speaking.

Proxemics: Use of space and physical distance.

Haptics: Use of touch (e.g., handshake, pat on the back).

Appearance: Clothing, grooming, and overall physical presentation.

Chronemics: Use of time, such as punctuality.

Key Features

It is often subconscious and spontaneous.

It supports, complements, or contradicts verbal communication.

It can communicate emotions more effectively than words.

Examples

Smiling to show friendliness.

Folding arms to indicate defensiveness or disinterest.

Maintaining eye contact to show attentiveness.

Importance

Enhances understanding of the speaker's true feelings.

Helps to build trust and emotional connection.

Crucial in cultures where body language plays a strong role in communication

Interpersonal Communication

Interpersonal communication is the exchange of information between two or more people. It can occur in formal or informal contexts and may involve verbal, non-verbal, or written means.

Forms of Interpersonal Communication:

Dyadic communication: Between two people (e.g., friend-to-friend, doctor-patient).

4

Group communication: Small group discussions or teamwork.

Public communication: One person communicating with a larger audience.

Key Features

It involves interaction and feedback.

It can be face-to-face or mediated (e.g., phone, email, social media).

It is dynamic, transactional, and context-dependent.

Examples

A job interview.

A parent discussing academic performance with a teacher.

Two colleagues collaborating on a project.

Importance

Builds relationships and social connections.

Enables effective teamwork and collaboration.

Helps resolve conflicts and enhance understanding.

Intrapersonal Communication

Intrapersonal communication is the internal dialogue or communication that takes place within an individual. It includes thinking, reflection, self-talk, decision-making, and emotional processing.

Forms of Intrapersonal Communication

Self-concept: How you see yourself.

Internal dialogue: Silent self-talk or mental rehearsal.

Emotional reflection: Processing feelings and reactions.

Key Features

Private and silent.

Helps in personal reasoning and emotional regulation.

Influences one's confidence, behavior, and choices.

Examples

Thinking about what to say in a conversation.

5

Reflecting on a past experience.

Encouraging oneself before a public presentation.

Importance

Develops self-awareness and emotional intelligence.

Helps in goal setting and personal motivation.

Crucial for decision-making and self-improvement.

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN ORAL AND WRITTEN COMMUNICATION

One of the most significant differences between face-to face (oral) and written communication is that the immediate feedback present in oral communication is not present in written communication. Since feedback is very important in communication, delayed feedback which happens in written communication, can cause misunderstanding, thereby affecting effective communication. Another difference is that written communication has a permanency which is missing in oral communication.

ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES OF VERBAL COMMUNICATIONS

METHODS

Written Verbal Communication (Letters, Memos, Reports, Minutes of meetings, Articles, Press-release)

Advantages

- i. Provides written records and evidence of dispatch and receipt.
- ii. Capable of relaying complex ideas.
- iii. Provides analysis, evaluation, and summary.
- iv. Disseminates information to dispersed receiver.

- v. Can confirm, interpret, and clarify oral communication.
- vi. Forms basis of contract or agreement.

Disadvantages

- i. Can take time to produce.
- ii. Can be expensive.
- iii. Tends to be more formal and distant.

6

- iv. Instant feedback is not possible.
- v. Difficult to modify message once dispatched.
- vi. Does not allow for immediate exchange of opinions, views or attitudes.

Oral Verbal Communication (Face-to-face conversation, Interview, Meeting, Oral briefing, Public address, Oral presentation, Telephone call, Conference, Training session)

Advantages

- i. Direct medium of communication.
- ii. Advantages of physical proximity and usually includes both sight and sound of sender and receiver.
- iii. Instant interchange of opinions, views, attitudes.
- iv. Instantaneous feedback.
- v. Easier to convince or persuade.
- vi. Allows for contribution and participation from all present.
- vii. Inexpensive.

Disadvantages

- i. More difficult to hold ground in face of opposition.
- ii. More difficult to control when a number of people take part.
- iii. Lack of time to think things through.
- iv. Quality of decision-making may be inferior.
- v. Sometimes disputes result over what was agreed.

THE PROCESS OF COMMUNICATION

Communication is fundamentally a process, that is, a dynamic, continuous flow of information and interaction between people. It involves several interrelated steps and elements working together to ensure that a message is sent, received, understood, and acted upon.

What is a Process?

A process is a series of actions or steps taken to achieve a particular end. Communication is not a one-time act but an ongoing cycle or process. The communication process is relatively simple and divided into three basic components. It is not just a single action but a chain of several

7

interdependent actions. Essentially, the communication process involves actions, reactions, and interactions.

Actions: this refers to the initiative taken by someone (a sender) or an encoder to share information, observation, or opinion with others. He may do so by speaking, writing, drawing, or gesturing.

Reaction: this is a response to the action taken by the sender. In other words, the person addressed (receiver) responds to the sender's initiative of starting the communication. Depending on the type of response given, we are able to determine whether or not the receiver is willing to be party to the communication encounter.

Interaction: this is primarily concerned with the exchange of messages between the sender and receiver. If the receiver is willing to participate, he sends his response to the initiator.

The responses may be verbal or non-verbal. An interaction may involve two or more persons provided those who take part in the encounter share common experiences, codes or symbols. There will be a continuous exchange among them as long as there is information to share or ideas and thought to put across.

Understanding communication as a process helps us see it as more than just speaking or writing. It's an interactive and purposeful exchange, where each step contributes to the effectiveness of the message. Recognizing the process allows us to identify and fix breakdowns in communication.

ACTION

REACTION

INTERACTION

8

ELEMENTS OF COMMUNICATION

- i. **Stimulus-** this is the situation (the happening) that starts or sets the communication in motion. This is basically the reason one has for communicating which may be to inform, educate, advise, scold, entertain, e.t.c.
- ii. **The Encoder/Source/Sender-** this is the individual, group or organization who begins the communication or conversation. The source is the initiator because he begins the communication process. As the source or encoder, he packages the message in a way that it can be communicated. When encoding a message, the sender has to begin by deciding what to transmit or send out. It is important for the source or encoder to use symbols familiar to the intended receiver, otherwise there will be miscommunication.
- iii. **The Message-** this is the intention, idea, feeling, knowledge, opinion, information, or thought sent across to the receiver. In a communication situation, the message is the sum total of all that the source/encoder desires to pass across to the decoder or receiver. When we speak, the speech is the message. When we gesture, the movements of our arms, the expressions on our faces are the message.
- iv. **The Channel-** to send or transmit a message, the sender uses some kind of channel (also known as a medium). The channel is the means by which we transfer the

message from the sender to the receiver and from the receiver back to the sender. The channel could be oral, written, or non-verbal. Common channels include the telephone and a variety of written forms such as reports, letter and memos. The channel must be right if the message must be delivered effectively. If the sender uses an inappropriate channel, his message may not reach the intended recipients/receivers.

v. The Decoder/Receiver- the decoder is the receiver of the message. He is the target audience for the message. All the source/sender's effort to communicate is to inform or affect the attitude of the receiver. That is why communication must be receiver-centered. For communication to be effective and successful, the receiver must correctly interpret the sender's message.

9

vi. Feedback- this is the reaction that the receiver gives to the message. The receiver may agree or disagree. The feedback may be verbal or non-verbal; it can also be written or oral. Communication is incomplete without feedback. It confirms that the message is well received and understood. Feedback guides the source in the communication process and helps him to know when to alter or modify his message if not properly received. Feedback is positive when it shows that the message has been well received and understood and it could be negative when it shows that the intended effect has not been achieved.

Effective communication is crucial (important) for building relationships, fostering understanding, resolving conflicts, making informed decisions, and collaborating successfully in various aspects of life, including personal, professional, and social interactions. It requires both parties to be actively engaged in the process, listening carefully and ensuring that the intended message is conveyed accurately.

Miscommunication can lead to misunderstandings, confusion and even conflict. To avoid this, it is very important to communicate clearly and effectively.

The Determinants of Communication Effectiveness

Effective communication is essential (important) to the success of any organization, as well as other human relationships. Communication can be described as a two-way street, therefore both the person communicating and the one being communicated to has to participate. The success of a communication or a conversation relies on both the source and the receiver. It is important to understand the key factors that enhance or hinder effectiveness in communication.

The key factors that determine effective communication are:

- i. Communication skills- there are five verbal communication skills. Two of these are encoding skills (speaking and writing). Two of them are decoding skills (reading and listening). The fifth one is important for both encoding and decoding (reasoning). The more developed the communication skills of the communicators are, the more their chances of communicating effectively.
- ii. Attitude- the attitude of the sender affects the way in which he communicates. A

positive attitude produces positive results, while a negative attitude produces negative results.

A positive, open-minded attitude is key to good communication. When people are positive and open minded, they are more likely to be able to see things from the other person's perspective and understand where they are coming from. They are also more likely to be willing to listen and consider different points of view. On the other hand, a negative attitude can make it difficult to communicate effectively. If a person is close minded, they may not be willing to listen or consider new ideas. This can lead to misunderstanding and conflict.

iii. Knowledge level- the amount of knowledge that the sender/source has about his subject matter/topic/content, will affect his message. This is because one cannot communicate what he/she does not know, therefore to communicate with maximum effectiveness; the sender must have a good knowledge of the content he wants to communicate.

iv. Socio-cultural system- Social-cultural systems significantly influence communication effectiveness by shaping how individuals perceive, interpret, and engage in communication. These systems include the values, norms, belief, customs, and practices that are prevalent within a particular society or cultural group. Understanding these socio-cultural factors is crucial for effective communication especially in diverse or cross-cultural interactions. A sender/source's message is influenced by his socio-cultural system, the groups he belongs to, his social class, his values and standards, his perception, all affect the way he communicates. The way a receiver receives and interprets messages, is also influenced by his socio-cultural system.

To communicate effectively, you must develop yourself in the above listed areas. These same factors affect the receiver in communication. Note that the most important element in any communication situation is the receiver. The receiver must be kept in mind if there must be an effective communication, for if your receiver does not understand you, you have not communicated effectively.

NOISE IN COMMUNICATION

Noise is interference (barrier) that keeps a message from being understood or accurately interpreted. It is a potent (strong) barrier to effective communication. Noise may be in different forms.

11

i. Physical noise- this comes from the environment and keeps the message from being heard and understood. It may be from loud conversations, side talks at meetings, vehicular sounds, sound from work men's tool, e.t.c.

ii. Psychological noise- this comes from within as a result of poor mental attitude, depression, emotional stress, personal bias against the speaker e.t.c.

iii. Linguistic noise- this comes from the sender/source's inability to understand the

language of communication accurately and appropriately. It may be a grammatical noise manifested in form of defects in the use of the rules of grammar of a language, and faulty sentence structure. It may be semantic as in wrong use of words or use of unfamiliar words, misspellings, e.t.c. it could also be phonological manifested in incorrect pronunciation.

iv. Physiological noise- this is from interference from the body in form of bodily discomforts, feeling of hunger and tiredness, poor hearing, stammering or stuttering, effects of medications, eye defects or other mental or emotional disabilities.

THE PURPOSE OF COMMUNICATION

Why do we communicate?

The purpose of communication is our reason for communication. What do we wish to achieve when we communicate?

Communication

↓ _____ ↓ _____ ↓

Inform Persuade Entertain

Communication to Inform- this involves passing on information to an audience with the intention of educating or imparting knowledge. Informative messages can be used to give instructions and information on codes, steps and procedures in work places, e.t.c.

Communication to persuade- Persuasion is an attempt to influence people's beliefs, attitudes, intentions and behavior in relation to an event, idea, object or persons. Persuasion is achieved

12

through written or spoken communication that conveys information, thoughts, emotions, logic and arguments.

Communication to entertain- this is another aim of communication. Communication can be used for entertainment to stimulate the socialization of individuals in society. This can be done through literature/drama.

Note that in looking at the purpose of communication, it is very important for the sender/encoder to consider the response he desires to get from the receiver.

THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN COMMUNICATION AND LANGUAGE

What is Language?

Language can be defined as a code for communication.

Can communication take place without language?

Language is the primary tool for communication. It is a structured system of symbols and rules used to convey messages. Without language, communication would be limited to non-verbal cues. Language enhances clarity, specificity, and understanding in communication.

Language is a dominant factor in communication, there is no communication without language. It is with the help of language that we communicate, whether orally (speech), written (letters) or gesture (as in signs). Language then is a code with which we encode our messages and through

which the messages are decoded by the receivers. Note that Language and Communication are like Siamese twins (joined together), one is not possible without the other. If we must communicate effectively, we must have a good command of language.

COMMUNICATION PROBLEMS

i. Limitation to the receiver's capacity- there can be a breakdown in communication if the receiver does not have the capacity to understand the sender's message. this can be as a result of the receiver's academic background, intelligence level or his level of reasoning.

ii. Noise- this includes any external or internal factor that interferes with the reception of messages. Noise could be physical, physiological, psychological or linguistic. When

13

there is noise in the communication process, the effectiveness of communication is hindered.

iii. Misunderstanding- when the receiver does not understand the sender's message, there is bound to be misunderstanding, and consequently, communication would be ineffective. Ensure to use clear and simply terms or words in communicating so that your receiver will understand you.

iv. Disagreement- when the receiver does not agree with the sender's view, there is the tendency to read a different interpretation to the sender's message.

THE IMPACT OF MOTHER TONGUE INTERFERENCE ON COMMUNICATION

The concept of Mother tongue Interference

A language that is learnt and acquired from an individual's environment as he grows is called first language, mother tongue or L1. If this person has cause to learn another language later in life, this is called second language or L2. Mother tongue Interference is said to take place if L1 influences L2. Mother tongue Interference, therefore, is the trace left by someone's native language upon the foreign language he is trying to acquire. Mother tongue interference, also known as language transfer, occurs when the structure, sounds, or usage rules of a speaker's first language (L1) negatively affect their use of a second language (L2). In Nigeria, this most often refers to how indigenous Nigerian languages influence the learning and usage of English, which is the country's official language and a major medium of instruction.

Levels of Mother tongue interference

Phonological Level- phonological interference occurs when due to the speech sounds of L1 certain sounds of L2 cannot be pronounced or are wrongly pronounced. This happens mostly as a result of differences in sound systems (phonology) of languages or dialects. When speakers of different languages or dialects interact, differences in their pronunciations, accents or intonations can lead to communication challenges. Phonological interference can cause linguistic noise which can lead to breakdown in communication. Nigerian languages do not have all the phonemes (sounds) of English, so speakers often substitute difficult English sounds with familiar local ones.

Examples:

14

/θ/ → /t/: "think" pronounced as "tink"

/ʃ/ → /s/: "she" pronounced as "see"

/z/ → /s/: "zoo" pronounced as "soo"

Semantic interference- this occurs when due to L1, certain words are misused and wrong meanings given to them. This occurs when a word from the mother tongue is used with a meaning that does not correspond exactly in English. Semantic interference in communication also refers to misunderstandings or confusion that arises from the meanings of words, phrases, or symbols within a message. This type of interference occurs when the sender and the receiver of a message assign different meanings to the same word or phrase, leading to misinterpretation. Semantic interference can make it difficult to understand the actual meaning of words that are being said. For example, if someone uses a lot of slangs, it can be difficult to understand what they are saying.

Syntactic interference- this occurs when due to the interference of L1, the sentence pattern (SVOA in English) is disrupted. Syntactic interference in communication refers to misunderstandings or confusion that arises due to differences in the structure of grammar (syntax) of languages. Syntax involves the rules and patterns that govern how words are combined to form sentences and convey meaning. When speakers of different languages or dialects communicate, differences in syntactic structures can lead to errors or misinterpretations that can affect clarity and effectiveness of communication. Local language structures may influence how English sentences are constructed.

Examples:

"She is having two brothers" instead of "She has two brothers"

"He come yesterday" instead of "He came yesterday"

"The girl beautiful" instead of "The girl is beautiful"

CODE SWITCHING/CODE MIXING/DISSONANCE

A code is a system of sounds, symbols or signs used by a group of people to communicate with one another. A speaker could choose a code that his audience understands to communicate with

15

them. In other words, to pass information or messages to the listeners, the speaker should select a language they know.

Code Mixing- this is the use of two or more languages by a bilingual (a person who knows and speaks two languages) or a multilingual (a person who knows and speaks more than two languages), interchangeably in the same speech, social situation, or communication event. This statement indicates that the speaker combines two or more languages in an utterance. The languages are used within the same utterance, spoken or written, with an audience who understands them.

Examples:

Please pass me the cup of ruwan sanyi. (Hausa/English Language)

I need to gozie him for helping me. (Igbo and English language)

I am feeling very tired, let me sun (sleep). (Yoruba and English language)

Code switching- this is the switch from one language to another by a speaker in a single conversation. This occurs when speakers switch back and forth between two or more languages or language varieties in the context of a single conversation or utterance. When people speak more than one language, they can switch from one language to another while communicating. When the speaker makes the first utterance in a particular language, he may decide to make the next utterance in another language. Code switching shows proficiency and competence. This phenomenon often occurs in multilingual communities where speakers switch languages based on the social context, the people they are communicating with, or the topic of discussion.

In Nigeria, speakers often switch between English and indigenous languages like Hausa, Igbo, Yoruba, or Nigerian Pidgin, especially in informal conversations or when emphasizing a point.

Examples:

I will see you tomorrow, insha Allah. (English to Hausa/Arabic expression)

I will call you later. Kedu ka I di, I hope you are fine? (Igbo/English language)

We have finished the project. Amma zan tafi yanzu, see you next week. (Hausa/ English Language)

16

I am going to the market. I will buy eja ati amala for dinner. (Yoruba/English language)

Our lecturer said the exam will be tough. Me I don dey pray already. (English/Pidgin)

The difference between Code mixing and Code switching is that while code mixing involves the blending of words or phrases from different languages within the same sentence, often to convey meaning more naturally or precisely, code switching involves changing languages between sentences or clauses, reflecting a shift in context or audience.

Dissonance in communication occurs when there's a conflict or contradiction in communication, such as between verbal and non-verbal cues, or when the message contradicts the audience's beliefs, emotions, or expectations. This can occur when the verbal message (what is said) and the nonverbal cues (such as tone, body language, or facial expressions) do not align, or when the message being communicated is in conflict with the beliefs, values, or expectation of the receiver. For example, if someone says they are fine but their body language suggests they are upset, this creates dissonance in communication. The receiver of the message may feel confused or distrustful because the verbal and nonverbal messages are contradictory. Dissonance in communication can lead to misunderstandings, reduced credibility, and difficulty in building trust. For communication to be effective, ensure that verbal messages are consistent with nonverbal cues and that they are aligned with the expectations and beliefs of the receiver(s).

Examples:

A mother shouts “I’m not angry!” while yelling and banging the table.

A lecturer says “You are all brilliant students,” while frowning and shaking his head.

A student tells a lecturer “I respect you sir” while rolling their eyes.

17

ORAL ENGLISH

Oral English refers to the spoken aspect of the English language. It focuses on the correct pronunciation of sounds, proper articulation of words, the use of stress and intonation, and effective communication in spoken form.

Organs of Speech

The organs of speech are the parts of the human body involved in producing speech. They include: (Lips, Teeth, Tongue, Alveolar ridge, Hard palate, Soft palate (velum), Uvula, Glottis, Vocal cords, Nasal cavity, Oral cavity, Lungs, Diaphragm)

These organs work together to produce and articulate sounds.

Phonemes of English

Phonemes are the smallest units of sound in a language that can differentiate meaning. There are 44 phonemes in the English language; it is from them that countless number of English sounds can be formed. The phonemes are divided into 24 consonant sounds and 20 vowel sounds (12 pure vowels and 8 diphthongs).

Consonant Sounds

Consonants are speech sounds produced when airflow is obstructed in some way by the articulatory organs (lips, teeth, tongue, palate). There are 24 consonant sounds in English.

1. /p/- pen, top, paper, people, apple
2. /b/ - back, big, baby, table, club
3. /t/- time, top, water, later, bat
4. /d/ - dog, do, dance, hard, bed
5. /k/ - cat, back, cook, class, king
6. /g/ - go, good, get, bag, game
7. /f/- fan, fish, leaf, coffee, phone

18

8. /v/ - van, very, love, move, oven
9. /θ/ - think, three, bath, both, thank
10. /ð/ - this, that, mother, breathe, though
11. /s/ - see, sun, kiss, pass, sister
12. /z/- zoo, buzz, is, prize, lazy
13. /ʃ/ - she, shop, crash, nation, sure
14. /ʒ/- measure, vision, television, pleasure, genre

15. /tʃ/ – chip, chin, match, teacher, watch
16. /dʒ/ – jam, judge, large, edge, ginger
17. /m/ – man, mother, time, room, come
18. /n/ – no, not, name, ten, dinner
19. /ŋ/ – sing, long, song, king, bringing
20. /l/ – love, let, tell, little, bell
21. /r/ – red, right, very, arrive, around
22. /j/ – yes, yellow, young, you, use
23. /w/ – we, wet, what, win, window
24. /h/ – hat, hope, house, hello, hot

Vowel Sounds

Vowels are speech sounds made without any significant constriction of airflow. They are 20 in number and are divided into pure vowels and diphthongs. The pure vowels are 12 in number comprising 5 long vowels, and 7 short ones, while the diphthongs are 8 in number.

Monophthongs (12)

19

1. /i:/ – sheep, seat, meet, machine, please
2. /ɪ/ – ship, sit, bid, middle, little
3. /e/ – bed, pen, said, head, ready
4. /æ/ – cat, man, bat, apple, back
5. /ʌ/ – cup, love, sun, luck, mother
6. /ɑ:/ – car, father, heart, part, start
7. /ɒ/ – hot, clock, dog, long, not *(mainly British)*
8. /ɔ:/ – call, four, law, door, talk
9. /ʊ/ – book, good, put, full, look
10. /u:/ – boot, moon, school, food, true
11. /ɜ:/ – bird, girl, learn, word, nurse
12. /ə/ – about, teacher, banana, ago, problem (schwa – weak vowel)

Diphthongs (8)

13. /eɪ/ – face, day, say, break, rain
14. /aɪ/ – my, fly, time, try, right
15. /ɔɪ/ – boy, toy, coin, enjoy, oil
16. /aʊ/ – now, how, out, loud, shout
17. /əʊ/ – no, go, home, road, open *(British)*
18. /ɪə/ – ear, beer, idea, near, cheer

19. /eə/ – air, care, share, dare, parent

20. /ʊə/ – pure, sure, cure, tourist, endure

20

Stress

Stress refers to the emphasis placed on certain syllables or words during speech. A syllable is a unit of pronunciation having one vowel sound, with or without surrounding consonants, forming the whole or part of a word. Stress is the sound difference achieved by pronouncing one syllable more forcefully than another. A stressed syllable is louder, longer, and said with a higher pitch than an unstressed one. Stress can simply be defined as the force with which a syllable is pronounced. Stress can change the meaning of words, for example, REcord (Noun), and reCORD (verb). We do not stress every syllable, and we do not stress consonants.

Types of Stress:

i. Word Stress: Emphasis on a particular syllable within a word.

`Table` (not taBLE)

`PREsent` (noun) vs pre`SENT` (verb)

Word stress can sometimes change not only the pronunciation, but also the meaning, and the grammatical classes of words. When a word has both a noun and a verb form, the noun is stressed on the first syllable, while the verb is stressed on the second syllable.

Examples

NOUNS VERBS

PROgress Progress

Record reCORD

PREsent Present

Object Object

CONduct Conduct

PROduce proDUCE

PERmit Permit

CONtract Contract

CONflict Conflict

21

CONtest Contest

CONvert Convert

SUSpect Suspect

EXtract exTRACT

COMbat comBAT

PROtest proTEST

Import Import

Export Export

SUBject Subject

Rules of Word Stress:

i. Monosyllabic words (one syllable words): they are usually stressed.

Example: dog, run, sit, play, kind e.t.c.

ii. Disyllabic (two-syllable) nouns/adjectives: stressed usually on the first syllable

Examples: TAble, DOctor, Happy, FARmer,

iii. Disyllabic (two-syllable) verbs: stressed on the second syllable

Examples: reLAX, aRRIVE, deCIDE, inSIST, reDEEM e.t.c

iv. Compound nouns: stressed on the first word

Examples: BLACKboard, FOOTball

v. Compound adjectives/verbs: stressed on the second word

Examples: old-FASHioned, underSTAND

ii. Sentence Stress:

Certain words in a sentence (usually content words like nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs) are stressed, while grammatical words (e.g., articles, prepositions) are unstressed.

Example

She bought a new car yesterday.

22

(Stressed words: bought, new, car)

Intonation

Intonation is the variation in pitch while speaking. It can show emotions, attitudes, grammatical functions (like asking a question), or emphasis.

Types of Intonation Patterns

i. Falling Intonation (↘)

This is generally used for statements, commands, Interjections/exclamations, and WH-questions.

Examples:

i. Statements: She is coming.

ii. WH-questions: What is your name?

iii. Commands: Get out of my room.

iv. Interjections/exclamations: How nice of you to have remembered me!

ii. Rising Intonation (↗)

Used for yes/no questions, surprise, or to show uncertainty.

Examples

i. Are you ready?

ii. Is it raining?

iii. Really?

iv. He stole the money?

23

CORRESPONDENCE

What is correspondence?

Correspondence often refers to the exchange of letters or written messages between individuals or organizations. It can be formal or informal and may be conducted through traditional mail (letter writing) or electronic means like email.

Types of Correspondence

Letters- Letter writing is very vital in everyday life. Letter writing is specifically divided into two types. They are: Informal or friendly letters, and Formal or business letters such as job application letter, request letter, recommendation letter, social or invitation letter, letter of complaints, memos, cover letter, e.t.c

Memo- A memo or memorandum is a type of business document that is used to communicate information within an organization. Memos are typically brief and to the point, and they usually follow a standard format. The memo should include a heading that states the purpose of the memo, followed by a body that contains the main points of the message. The memo should also include a closing that states the writer's name and contact. A well written memo is informative and concise.

Circular – These are letters or documents distributed to a group of people to provide information or instructions. They are ideal for disseminating information to a broad audience, such as employees or members of an organization. Circulars can be used to announce events, share policies or procedures, or provide updates on current activities.

Notices- A notice is a short and formal announcement or advertisement that informs or reminds people of something. Notices are frequently used to announce meetings, deadlines, or important events. Notices are short and concise, and are designed to communicate specific information promptly and efficiently. A notice is used when many people in the organization have to be given the same information. It is short and the language is simple.

24

The Differences between formal and informal letters

Informal Letters

Informal letters are the letters we write to our friends, relatives, parents, siblings, acquaintances and to other contemporaries.

Features of an informal letter

- i. It must be conversational in tone and simple.
- ii. It is chatty: That is, the writer opens his mind freely and discusses some personal issues with the receiver.
- iii. The language must be familiar, with the use of colloquialisms, and slang. The slang to be used must not be abusive. Note that slang is not used when a younger person writes to his elders. There must be a wary use of slang and colloquial expressions.
- iv. Short and contracted form of language is obligatory. Examples: you'd, isn't, can't,

I'm, you've, e.t.c. All these short forms of expressions make the informal letters sound fully informal.

Formal Letters

These are correspondences documented for exchanging official information. That is, they are letters meant for offices and other official purposes. Formal letters include;

Letters to organizations:

Applying for jobs

Making requests

Making recommendations

Cover letters for curriculum vitae

Placing orders

Invitations, Memos, Circulars

25

Letters to institutions asking for permission and making complaints

Features of a Formal Letter

- i. Clarity- A formal letter must give clear information.
- ii. Conciseness- A good formal letter must be straight to the point. Avoid the use of irrelevant expressions. Choose your words properly.
- iii. Formal Tone- Formal letters maintain a formal and professional tone throughout the communication. The language used is polite and devoid of casual or informal expressions.
- iv. Formal Greetings and Closing- Formal letters begin with a formal salutation, and closes with a polite and respectful closing phrases (Yours sincerely or Yours faithfully), followed by the sender's signature and name.
- v. No abbreviations or slangs are used in formal letters.

Parts of a Letter

Informal Letters

The address- The only address required in an informal letter is the writer's address. Each word in the address must start with a capital letter. Your address may be written either in block or punctuated style or slant and unpunctuated style.

Examples:

Block or Punctuated:

Petroleum Training Institute,

P.M.B 20,

Effurun,

Delta State.

6th September, 2023.

Slant or Unpunctuated style:

26

Petroleum Training Institute

P.M.B 20

Effurun

Delta State

6th September 2023

Date- This should be written on the line following the last line of the address. It is always preferable to write your date clearly in both figures and letters. Avoid writing your date in figures only. This is to avoid ambiguity. 06/09/2023 in British English is 6th September 2023, while in American English it is June 9th 2023. Any of these forms is correct:

12 October, 2012.

October 12, 2012.

12th October, 2012.

Also note the comma after the month and the full stop after the year. Avoid using abbreviations for months.

Salutation/Opening Greeting- Your salutation/opening greeting must slant from the margin on the left side of your writing paper, on the line immediately after the date. Examples: Dear Dad, Dear Mom, Dear Ugo (Note that it is wrong to just write Dear friend in Informal letters without mentioning the name of your friend).

Introductory Paragraph- In the first paragraph, the welfare of the recipient should be enquired after. The writer should also express his own welfare to the recipient. Your introductory paragraph must be void of clichés and slangs like “I hope you’re really swimming in the ocean of good health”. Instead make your expressions simple and clear like “I hope you’re sound in health?”

Body of the letter- In this part, the main topic of the letter should be introduced in detail. Though chatty language and other colloquial expressions are welcomed in informal letters, the expressions to be used must be acceptable and appropriate for the letters. For instance, when

27

writing to adult relations, or even your parents, the language should be censored, some respect should be shown.

Conclusion- Your conclusion should indicate that your conversation is really coming to a close. All this point, send your regards only to those known to both of you.

Complimentary close- Your complimentary close should be intentionally intimate just as the salutation. This is to maintain a cordial relationship or familiarity with the recipient. The following expressions can be used in the complimentary close: ‘Yours affectionately’, ‘Yours ever’, ‘Your loving son/daughter’. Note ‘Yours’ starts with capital Y. Any other word following the letter must be written in small letter. There is no apostrophe either before or after S in yours.

The last word in the complimentary close goes with a comma. After this, your first name or nickname (especially letter to a friend) is written. There must be a full stop at the end of your name.

Formal Letters

Writer's address----this appears on the top right-hand corner of the writing paper. The writer's address is the origin of the letter and must never be omitted.

Date----- This follows immediately after the writer's address. Make sure to write the month in word.

The recipient's designation (title)---- E.g The Director, The Principal, The Manager, The Chairman.

The recipient's address---- This should be written on the left-hand corner of the letter.

Salutation or Greeting-----Dear Sir or Madam; this expression is used when you do not know the name of the person you are writing to. Dear Mr. Mohammed; this type of expression is used when you know the name of the recipient. Use these titles in this case Mr, Mrs, Miss, Ms, Dr etc and the surname only. If you are writing to a woman and you do not know if she uses Mrs or Miss, you can use Ms, which stands for both married and single women.

Heading----- this can either be written in block or small letters. It is underlined if written in small letters and not underlined if written in block letters. The title tells the reader in clear terms what the letter is about. It should be short and straight to the point.

28

Body-----this contains the full information contained in the letter.

Complimentary close---this includes; 'Yours faithfully', used to end your official letter when you do not know the name of the person you are writing to, 'Yours sincerely', used when the salutation is done by addressing the recipient by the name, and Your signature; always append your signature and then write your name beneath your signature.

Note that the tone of a formal letter must be strictly formal. There should be no room to exchange pleasantries, jokes, chatty and colloquial expressions. It should be precise, direct and business minded. Moreover, the language should be as polite and official as possible, while informal letters can be more casual and may use slang or colloquial language.

29

Formal letter sample

100 Boundary Road,

Benin-city,

Edo State,

31st August, 2025.

Jahad Construction Ltd,

P.O.Box 1069,

Osogbo,

Osun State.

Dear Sir,

APPLICATION FOR THE POSITION OF A CIVIL ENGINEER

I write to apply for the position of a civil Engineer as advertised in the 22nd July 2023 edition of the Sun Newspaper.

I graduated from the University of Nigeria in 2019 with a second class upper division in civil and structural Engineering.

The enclosed CV demonstrates my significant experience in overseeing a wide range of civil engineering projects, including roads, bridges and sewer systems. I can plan, design and oversee construction effectively. In addition, the projects that I have undertaken have honed my skills in building strong working relationships with clients, and ensuring a quality process from start to finish. I am able to supervise the design of new projects as well as review and improve existing structures and I have provided examples of these in my CV.

I would welcome the opportunity to tell you how my skills and experience would be an asset to your organization and I am available for an interview at any time.

Thank you for your consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Signature

Name

30

Informal letter sample

Petroleum Training Institute,

P.M.B 20,

Effurun,

Delta State,

Nigeria.

31st August, 2025.

My dear Kenny,

Many thanks for your interesting letter which I received last week. How about your mum, Dad and Juliet? I hope Juliet has returned from the boarding school? I really miss all of you. Ejiro my younger brother is also expressing his heartfelt regards to you all.

I learnt from the last letter you wrote me that your school will be closing for the Christmas holidays on the 12th of December. I will be very glad if you spend the holiday with us at Yankari, Bauchi State. After a long hectic life in the city, I am sure you will really feel happy in this part of the world. The rural environment will add splendor and succor to your mind and energise you more for serious life over there in Ireland. The Yankari game reserves and Wuse lake are special attractions here. Apart from these, my parents have been getting everything

ready in welcoming you. You can trust the hospitable nature of my dear mum. In fact, she has promised to prepare Ukodo, your favourite food, to celebrate your arrival. Besides, Miky, Tinu and Chuzy are all warming up to give you a warm welcome. All our family members will be very glad to have you with us. Please do come quickly; we are dearly waiting for you.

Your loving friend,

Tega

31

COMPREHENSION AND INTERPRETATION

Comprehension is an important language and communication skill. It refers to the ability to read, understand, and interpret written texts. It involves decoding the literal meaning of words and grasping the implied or figurative meanings. Interpretation goes a step further, it involves analyzing the message, making inferences, drawing conclusions, and understanding the writer's tone, purpose, and techniques.

In comprehension passages, the ability to identify the major or the topic sentence in a paragraph or in a passage is very important. The topic sentence usually gives an insight or a picture of what is being said in the passage. It also indicates the subject matter of the passage. At times, the topic sentence comes first in the passage. However, it can come at the middle or even at end of the passage, but a critical reading of the passage will reveal to you where the topic sentence is located in the passage.

Points to note in understanding comprehension

1. Read the questions first to know what is demanded of you, this is very vital during examination to avoid unnecessary waste of time.
2. Read the passage carefully.
3. When you come across words that you are not familiar with, interpret them in the context in which they are used in the passage.
4. Ensure that your answers are what the passage is talking about.
5. Be watchful of signal words and phrases.
6. Distinguish between key points and supporting details.
7. Focus on key words or any word that is emphasized in the passage.
8. Things to avoid in answering comprehension questions
9. Do not misinterpret or deviate from the question.
10. Giving of two or more answers to more answers to a question should be avoided, excepted where stated.
11. Avoid giving your answers in single words or phrases, unless otherwise stated. Answers should be written in sentences.
12. When asked to give the synonyms or antonyms of words, do not use words that go out of context. The word must fit perfectly to substitute the one given in the passage.

32

13. Never overlook the instruction to any question.

14. Avoid repeating answers unnecessarily.

15. Do not copy back the question before answering it. It is a waste of time but make sure you number your answers well.

Skills Involved in Comprehension and Interpretation

i. Identifying Main Ideas in a Given Passage

The main idea is the central thought or message the writer wants to convey. It is usually found in the topic sentence, often the first or last sentence of a paragraph.

Strategies

Skim through the passage.

Look for repeated concepts or terms.

Ask: "What is this paragraph mostly about?"

Example

"Although Nigeria has diverse ethnic groups, unity can be achieved through mutual understanding."

Main Idea: Unity in Nigeria can be achieved through mutual understanding.

ii. Differentiating the Main Ideas from the Details in a Passage

Main ideas are general statements, while supporting details explain, illustrate, or provide evidence for the main idea. Details can be facts, examples, statistics, or anecdotes.

Tip: Ask, "Is this sentence essential to understanding the whole paragraph, or does it just support something more important?"

iii. Using the Main Idea to Anticipate Specific Details in a Passage

Once you understand the main idea, you can predict the type of details that will follow. This skill is useful during reading exams or academic study.

Example: If a paragraph begins with "Social media has both positive and negative effects," expect specific details on both benefits and drawbacks.

iv. Using Context Clues to Aid Comprehension

33

Context clues help readers infer the meaning of unfamiliar words. Types include:

Definition

Synonym

Antonym

Example

Inference

Example: "She is very meticulous, always paying attention to the smallest details." The word 'meticulous', means careful or precise.

v. Identifying Relationship Patterns of Ideas in a Passage

Look for transitions and signal words to identify patterns:

Comparison: similarly, likewise

Contrast: however, although

Cause and effect: because, therefore

Chronology: first, then, next

Enumeration: firstly, secondly

vi. Using Context Clues such as Definitions, Restatements, and Examples to Derive Meaning

Writers often restate difficult words using simpler expressions.

Example: "The child was elated, that is, extremely happy."

Example: "Various artifacts, such as pottery and tools, were found at the site."

vii. Explaining How Affixes Modify Meanings

Affixes are word parts added to base words to change meaning.

Prefixes: added to the beginning (e.g., un-, re-, pre-)

Suffixes: added to the end (e.g., -ment, -ness, -tion)

Examples:

happy - unhappy (prefix "un-" shows negation)

develop - development (suffix "-ment" forms a noun)

viii. Interpreting Figurative Language in a Passage

34

Figurative language includes similes, metaphors, personification, hyperbole, etc.

Examples:

"Time is a thief." Time passes quickly and steals moments.

"She cried a river." She cried a lot.

ix. Drawing Conclusions from Available Information

Conclusions are informed judgments based on the information provided. This involves inference, critical thinking, and logical reasoning.

Example: If the passage says, "The ground was wet and dark clouds loomed," we can conclude that it had recently rained or was about to rain.

35